EXAM HACK OF THE DAY

Writer's Effect — The 3-Step Method

CAIE 1123 Paper 1 — Question 2 | Worth 2 marks | By Miss Jaweria

What is a Writer's Effect question?

You are given a sentence from the text with a word or phrase highlighted. You must explain what effect the writer creates by using that specific word or phrase.

How the question is worded:

Read this sentence from the text:
"....." (lines X-X)
What effect does the writer want to suggest about [subject] by using the word(s) '[word]' to describe it?

The 3 Steps:

1 Synonym
Rewrite the word/phrase in simple words

2 Association
What do we commonly associate this word with?

3 Result
What feeling or mood does it create? (use an adjective)

Remember: Synonym + Association + Result (adjective) = FULL MARKS!
Write your answer in ONE sentence using this formula.

STEP-BY-STEP BREAKDOWN

Example Question:

Read this sentence from the text:

"The river roared as it surged through the rocks."

What effect does the writer want to suggest about the water by using the word 'roared'?

1 STEP 1 — Synonym (Literal Meaning)

Ask yourself: What does the word actually mean?

"Roared" means: to make a loud, deep sound

Synonyms: shout / scream / bellow / yell / boom

Tip: Pick the simplest, clearest synonym your examiner will understand.

2 STEP 2 — Common Association

Ask yourself: What do we usually imagine when we hear this word?

"Roared" is most commonly used to describe: lions

So the water is being compared to a wild animal / beast

Tip: Think — animals? weather? war? machines? What picture comes to mind?

3 STEP 3 — Result (Adjective)

Ask yourself: What feeling, mood, or quality does this create?

Using 'roared' to describe the river makes the water seem:

loud, dangerous, fast, powerful, threatening

Tip: Your result MUST be an adjective that describes the subject (the water, the person, etc.)

MODEL ANSWER (2/2):

The writer means the water is shouting, by using a word commonly associated with lions. This tells us that the water is loud and dangerous.

WORKED EXAMPLE 2

Example Question:

"He had a pair of horns with a forest of lethal-looking spikes, and he was about four feet high."

What effect does the writer create by using the phrase 'lethal-looking spikes' to describe Hortense's horns?

1 SYNONYM

"Lethal-looking spikes" means: deadly / fatal / killer thorns

Synonyms: deadly / fatal / killer / murderous

2 ASSOCIATION

"Spikes" are commonly associated with: poisonous plants / cacti

So the horns are being compared to something sharp and harmful

3 RESULT (ADJECTIVE)

This makes Hortense seem:

dangerous / threatening / terrifying

MODEL ANSWER (2/2):

The writer means Hortense had deadly thorns, by using a word commonly associated with cacti. This tells us that they are dangerous.

QUICK EXAMPLE 3 — 'hissed warning'

Step 1 (Synonym): alert / alarm / caution
Step 2 (Association): snakes
Step 3 (Result): problematic / chaotic / dangerous

Answer: The writer means it was an alert, by using a word associated with snakes. This tells us that the deer is problematic and dangerous.

YOUR ANSWER FORMULA

Write your answer in ONE sentence using this template:

"The writer means [subject] is/was (SYNONYM) ,
by using a word commonly associated with (ASSOCIATION) .
This tells us that [subject] is (RESULT — ADJECTIVE) ."

Common Associations to Remember:

Word(s)	Associated with...	Result (adjective)
roared / growled / snarled	lions / wild animals	**dangerous / fierce**
hissed / slithered	snakes	**threatening / sneaky**
howled / whipped	wolves / storms	**wild / uncontrollable**
crept / prowled / lurked	predators / thieves	**suspicious / secretive**
blazed / scorched / erupted	fire / volcanoes	**destructive / powerful**
flooded / surged / engulfed	water / tsunami	**overwhelming / unstoppable**
shattered / crumbled	glass / ruins	**fragile / broken**
devoured / gobbled	hungry animals	**greedy / desperate**
soared / glided	birds / planes	**free / graceful**
barked / snapped	dogs	**aggressive / harsh**

Result Adjectives from the Feelings List:

Positive: joyful, ecstatic, hopeful, optimistic, content, relieved, thrilled, motivated, proud, inspired

Negative: melancholic, furious, enraged, petrified, terrified, tense, anxious, pessimistic, desperate

Neutral: puzzled, perplexed, astonished, shocked, fascinated, mesmerised, self-conscious, insecure

Golden Rule: NEVER leave this question blank!

Even if you're unsure, give a synonym + an adjective = at least 1 mark.

MISS JAY
O & A LEVEL ENGLISH